

Society is organized on hierarchical structures that rely on the division of individuals into roles of authority and obedience. This framework is reinforced by social conditioning, which instills a sense of duty to comply with authority and the fear of consequences for defiance. Over time, this dynamic fosters a detachment between individuals and the outcomes of their actions, as they focus on fulfilling the expectations of authority over their own moral judgments. As a result, the ability of individual conscience to resist authority becomes significantly weakened.

A tendency exists within people that pulls them towards hierarchical structures, and it is this inclination that creates a desire to become obedient to those with power of authority. As Thomas Hobbes suggests, law and order is required for society to function or else it will become a state of war, therefore it can be understood why people pursue and submit to authority. Early in life, parents and teachers reward actions that demonstrate respect towards impersonal authority. What ensues is the development of a complacent mindset towards those who have certain symbols of higher rank and therefore higher authority (Milgram Obedience to Authority, 137). To organize people into hierarchical structures, those in power incentivize them with promises of protection and security from external threats and assurances of internal harmony and stability. This creates a sense of obligation to serve what is believed to be the greater good. Within societal structures, those with authority are “seen as something larger than the individual”, therefore justifying the loss and sequential lack of self-autonomy. The individual is conditioned to believe that the power of authority represents “an impersonal force whose dictates transcend mere human wish or desire”, overpowering their autonomy (Milgram Obedience to Authority, 144). In turn, the individual loses any sense of responsibility which weakens morality, leading to the development of unjust actions.

The submission to authority often involves individuals disconnecting from their personal identity or selfhood, prioritizing the demands of their role over their values. The transformation from being an individual to part of a collective is the beginning of a shift towards an agentic state of obedience to authority, resulting in the dissociation from one’s “own purposes”, and the adoption of seeing oneself “as an agent executing the wishes of another” (Milgram, Obedience to Authority, 133). This process is strengthened when the authority, and especially their commands, are viewed as legitimate and relevant to the individual’s conscience. The outcome is the development of trust and confidence in authority. This increases the power of the authority as the individual is focused on being reverent by upholding their sense of obligation and duty towards the authority and deterred from withdrawing as it would result in awkwardness (Milgram Obedience to Authority, 7). As the individual seeks approval, their “feeling and precepts are dominated by the presence of the authority” (Milgram Obedience to Authority, 144). Eventually, the primary motivation and concern of the individual is whether or not they are “living up to the expectations that the authority has of him” (Milgram, Obedience to Authority, 10). The accumulation of all

these alterations on the individual's conscience inhibits their ability to resist the power of authority. For an individual to overcome their sense of obligation towards the fulfillment of the authority's expectations of them, there must be a severe lapse in the relationship between the two. The individual's capacity to disobey and revert to autonomy is based on the ability of the authority's power to bind the individual to their relationship. The apprehension to oppose authority stems from societal norms which have created an environment conducive to conformity. Sequential actions in combination with situational obligations ensure that the individual will abide by social etiquette, as they have been rewarded for doing so previously.

The threat of potential ramifications for disobeying societal standards and pressures is a major asset to the power of authority, as it ensures that people worry about how they may be perceived, especially by those who are in power. Therefore the individual acts in accordance with those in authority, even if the actions are "alien to his nature" (Milgram Obedience to Authority, 147). There is a general fear and anxiety of challenging society's rules which have been internalized through constant reminders that it is essential to respect authority (Milgram Obedience to Authority, 152). Consequently, rather than going against the status quo, the individual aims to absolve themselves and remain seemingly in adherence to the authority. The desire to find justification for one's immoral actions through coping mechanisms such as denial, subterfuge, avoidance, rationalization, and casting off responsibility. One's conscience does not have the strength to resist the power of authority.

Ultimately, the hierarchical nature of society, combined with social conditioning and fear of repercussions, renders individual conscience too weak to resist authority's influence. To reach that degree of obedience towards an authoritative figure, the individual disassociates themselves from their actions' consequences. The result is a level of obedience that alters how actions and commands are perceived and interpreted, weakening the individual conscience's ability to resist the power of authority.

Works Cited

Stanley Milgram. *Obedience to Authority* (1974)